

THE GREATER GOOD?:  
TRADEOFFS BETWEEN SOCIAL CONNECTION AND STATUS IN DECISION-MAKING  
SCENARIOS

by

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The Greater Good?:

Tradeoffs Between Social Connection and Status in Decision-Making Scenarios

by

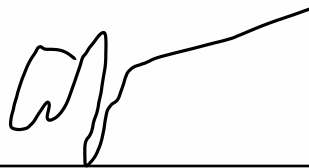
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## ABSTRACT

The Greater Good?:

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Strong social relationships have consistently emerged as predictors of well-being in the psychological literature. However, research has not distinguished between the intrinsic social value derived from these relationships and the status derived from them. We constructed the novel Relationship Orientation Scale to explore this gap, utilizing binary decision-making scenarios in which individuals were forced to pit these two goods against one another. Across two studies, we found that individuals displayed a significant, but by no means universal, preference for intrinsically rewarding social relationships. We found, also, that social media use and comparison orientation were negative predictors of relationship orientation, whereas agreeableness was a positive predictor. Notably, exploratory analyses revealed no association between relationship orientation and flourishing.

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## **The Greater Good?:**

### **Tradeoffs Between Social Connection and Status in Decision-Making Scenarios**

There is perhaps no philosophical question as fundamental as what constitutes a good life. Throughout human history, thinkers from countless backgrounds and disciplines have debated what types of lives individuals should pursue, as well as what heuristics individuals should follow to navigate the tradeoffs that the pursuit of these lives involves. Though the range of solutions proposed is far too vast to neatly summarize, answers have often pinpointed the prioritization of social relationships, the conscientious pursuit of social status and influence, and dedication to causes that transcend oneself. There is arguably no field of social science or philosophy divorced from these pivotal questions, and one can observe the same conversations and conflicts emerge time and again throughout intellectual history.

### **Eudaimonia & Strong Social Relationships**

The Greek philosopher Aristotle claimed that eudaimonia, a Greek term loosely translatable as well-being, is “something final and self-sufficient” and the “end of action” (Aristotle, trans. Sachs, 2002, Book I, Ch. 7). Yet, precisely what constitutes eudaimonia has been subject to debate for as long as the concept has existed. Aristippus of Cyrene, a Greek philosopher who predated Aristotle, felt that pleasure was the ultimate good; in fact, he argued sensual pleasure should be maximized, even if it involved spurning social conventions, angering peers, and refusing to delay personal gratification (O’Keefe, 2001). However, despite this hedonist perspective, he had a relatively nuanced view of pleasure itself. He recognized that the continuous pursuit of pleasure could result in diminishing returns (i.e., less and less pleasurable experiences) and argued that it was necessary to enjoy sensual pleasures without becoming

enslaved by them (Diogenes Laërtius, trans. Hicks, 1925, II.65). Epicurus, like Aristippus, agreed that pleasure was the ultimate good, yet felt that ataraxia (long-term tranquility) could not be achieved through indulgence and that, therefore, indulgence should be tempered (Epicurus, trans. Inwood & Gerson, 1994, p. 29). In fact, he argued that, due to the transient nature of pleasure, one must train the mind to engage with and appreciate sensory experiences—even minor ones (Klein, 2012). He famously proclaimed that he could indulge in a pot of cheese (Diogenes Laërtius, trans. Hicks, 1925).

Evidently, how to flourish in a world where the pursuit of pleasure leads to diminishing returns (if not outright suffering) is one of the defining issues of philosophy. It is only recently, however, that empirical methods have been brought to bear on these larger questions about the relationship between behavior and overall flourishing. Perhaps the most notable of these inquiries is the Harvard Study of Adult Development, a longitudinal study that began in 1938 and continues to this day (Vaillant, 2012, p. 1). The study, which documented the lives, habits, and health outcomes of hundreds of men from their teenage years through old age, found that the presence of strong social relationships is the strongest predictor of overall well-being. In the words of Dr. Robert Waldinger, the current director of the study, “Good relationships keep us happier and healthier. Period.” (Waldinger, 2015). Interestingly, this is roughly the same conclusion that both Epicurus and Aristotle came to millennia before. Epicurus claimed, “Of all the things which wisdom provides to make us entirely happy, much the greatest is the possession of friendship” (Epicurus, trans. Inwood & Gerson, 1994, p. 34). Likewise, Aristotle wrote, “Without friends no one would choose to live, though he had all other goods” (Aristotle, trans. Sachs, 2002, VIII.1, 1155a5).



In addition to finding that the presence of strong social relationships is associated with myriad positive outcomes, empirical methods have demonstrated that the presence of loneliness is associated with myriad negative outcomes—both mental and physical (Holt-Lunstad et al., 2010). Moreover, evidence suggests that messages about social exclusion are more impactful than messages relating to other types of misfortune (Baumeister et al., 2002). These findings suggest that psychological flourishing is not only enhanced by strong social connections and diminished by weak ones—but that it is shaped by how individuals conceive of their own capacity to navigate relationships, both in general terms and relative to others.

While both the Harvard Study of Adult Development and the research of Baumeister explored how strong social relationships are associated with well-being, neither looked at the nature of well-being itself. Other empirical work, however, has explored this emotional state on a more granular level. For instance, Kahneman (2011) famously distinguished between the experiencing self, which interacts with experience on a moment-to-moment basis, and the remembering self, which creates the overarching story of a given experience or one's life overall (p. 381). He initially felt that well-being should be defined through the perspective of the experiencing self, yet ultimately came to the conclusion that scientists must consider the remembering self as well (p. 402). In a sense, Kahneman concluded that the moment-to-moment pleasure emphasized by Aristippus and Epicurus must be balanced with reflective meaning-making.

In much the same way that Kahneman explored the granular components of well-being, Schnell (2011) constructed a survey to explore the types of activities and emotional states that are associated with a sense of meaning in one's life. For the purposes of this survey, Schnell did

not rely on individuals' explicit notions of meaningfulness. Instead, she conducted structured interviews with individuals about various components of their lives, as well as the meanings they found in those different components. She asked participants about these meanings until she was able to identify a so-called "ultimate meaning" which was irreducible to others. Using this technique, she identified twenty-six primary sources of meaning, excluding basic needs (such as those defined by Maslow, 1943) or extrinsic sources of meaning (such as financial security). (Financial security, for instance, was conceptualized as a "reducible source of meaning" in her paradigm—a means towards an end, not a source of meaning in and of itself). Schnell found that the degree of meaningfulness in one's life increased with both the number of sources of meaning (i.e., density) and the diversity of these sources. She also found that a construct called "generativity" was the most powerful predictor of meaningfulness in one's life. Generativity, a term coined by Erikson (1950) as part of his lifespan theory, is defined as "concern in establishing and guiding the next generation" (Vötter & Schnell, 2019). Among other things, it involves pursuits such as parenthood, teaching, civic engagement, and institutional involvement. It is associated with both adjustment and well-being in midlife: hence its place within Erikson's lifespan theory.

Schnell's identification of generativity as the strongest predictor of meaningfulness, though, raises nearly as many questions as it answers. The primary one is whether generativity should be viewed as a unique construct or merely as a proxy for the quality of one's social relationships. For better or worse, Schnell's identification of "ultimate meanings" led her to categorize sources of meaning using relatively abstract language; therefore, it is possible that these sources correspond fairly neatly to more colloquial (though perhaps slightly less specific)

categories of meaning. The quality of one's social relationships is a compelling candidate for a strong proxy. After all, longitudinal research (such as the Harvard Study of Adult Development) has established that the strongest predictor of overall well-being is the strength of one's social relationships. And, while well-being and meaningfulness are arguably not precise correlates, the amount of generativity one embodies in their life is undoubtedly confounded with the strength of one's social relationships; the majority (though not totality) of pursuits described as manifestations of generativity, by definition, involve social relationships. Moreover, one could even argue that these aforementioned pursuits are the *primary* ways in which individuals engage in social relationships in their adult lives. Therefore, it is possible that Schnell, through the identification of generativity as the strongest predictor of meaningfulness, has, in effect, corroborated the claims of the Harvard Study of Adult Development.

Another potential confound that must be explored is the status obtained from generativity-imbued engagements, as opposed to the meaning derived from the interpersonal qualities of social relationships themselves. Because, in much the same way that the majority of generativity-related pursuits necessarily involve the materialization of strong social relationships, the majority of generativity-related pursuits involve the expression and pursuit of status. For instance, the notion that one's actions will substantively impact future generations is arguably as pure an expression of the pursuit of status as exists. Furthermore, it is entirely possible that individuals are deriving meaning merely from the idea that they, as individuals, will be remembered; it is possible, in fact, that they do not even view the measurable impacts of their actions as relevant.

Before status and/or social relationships are disentangled from generativity, though, it is vital that status and intrinsic quality be disentangled from one another. Status is contingent on how one is perceived by others—and, arguably, one cannot attain any modicum of status without having strong social relationships mediating these perceptions. In the same vein, access to strong relationships is, to some degree, mediated by one's status; individuals with high status generally have more access to social relationships than others (as well as to intrinsically interesting non-relationship-based activities). As a result, countless choices individuals make end up boosting both their status and the quality of their relationships. Therefore, it is necessary to both identify and artificially create scenarios in which status and social relationships are pitted directly against one another in order to determine which of these two goods individuals generally prioritize. Only then can researchers meaningfully tease apart the meanings and implications of Schnell's survey, as well as of countless other surveys relating to meaning and well-being.

In order to address this gap in the literature, we created a survey juxtaposing these two variables against one another (the Relationship Orientation Scale or ROS). This survey contained twenty-two questions, each of which presented participants with a hypothetical social scenario and each of which asked participants to make a binary choice reflecting their general preference. The majority of the questions asked participants to make a binary choice between developing a rewarding social relationship and attaining a common proxy for status. (The aforementioned proxies included situations in which one could improve one's physical appearance, increase one's financial earnings, increase one's professional influence, and expand one's social group; they also included situations in which one could improve one's partner's physical appearance, increase one's partner's or friend's financial earnings, and increase one's partner's or friend's

professional influence). Others, though, explicitly asked participants to choose a propensity or philosophy that best reflected their general preferences.

This paper reports on two studies which utilize this instrument. The first study explores how individuals' levels of social connection and self-esteem relate to their relationship orientation, as well as whether these scores can be altered by induced emotional states. The second study examines how individuals' dispositional tendencies impact their Relationship Orientation Scale scores and whether these scores have any association with flourishing. The aim of these studies is not only to fill a theoretical gap in the scientific literature, but to, ultimately, understand what prevents individuals from leading lives that are aligned with their innermost values.

### **Study 1**

Study 1 examined whether participants gravitated towards the relationship oriented options or the status oriented options on the Relationship Orientation Scale. Due to the findings of the Harvard Study of Adult Development and the porous boundary between the pursuit of generativity and the pursuit of strong social relationships, we hypothesized that participants would choose the relationship oriented options significantly more often than the status oriented options.

In addition to determining whether individuals had a general preference for relationship-based options versus status oriented options, we felt that it was important to explore the stability and, therefore, ecological validity, of these preferences. Since individuals frequently make choices that are misaligned with their self-proclaimed preferences, we hypothesized that individuals' anchorings to the preferences outlined in our survey might become easily unmoored.

In particular, we hypothesized that a prime prompting participants to imagine themselves in a state of complete social isolation could lead them to display a statistically significant preference for status oriented options within the survey. In a sense, we imagined that status might function as “insurance” against the loss of relationships, and that, if individuals were primed to feel that their relationships were unstable, they might pursue status as a means towards this ultimate end. That being said, we also recognized the possibility that individuals might not make this leap and, instead, pursue the relationships themselves.

In addition to our two primary hypotheses, there were a number of exploratory hypotheses that we wished to examine as well. We felt that, in addition to including a prime pertaining to a state of social isolation, it was important to include a prime pertaining to a state of social connectedness. For, although negative primes are generally believed to be more salient than positive ones (Baumeister et al., 2001), some evidence suggests that positive states can have meaningful and sometimes comparable effects on affect (Fredrickson, 2001). Therefore, we hypothesized that individuals exposed to the prime pertaining to social connectedness would display a statistically significant preference for the social relationships on the survey. As with the prior prompt, though, we recognized the possibility that individuals primed to feel secure in their social relationships might place a stronger emphasis on the pursuit of status oriented goods.

We also included a number of previously validated scales to mediate for other variables, corroborate our hypotheses, and explore related (albeit different) hypotheses. For instance, we had participants complete the UCLA Loneliness Scale (Russell, 1996). We included this scale in order to explore how participants’ preferences on our survey (in any of the three conditions) might relate to their actual states of loneliness and social connectedness. We hypothesized that

there would be a negative correlation between participants' scores on the UCLA Loneliness Scale and participants' preferences for intrinsically rewarding options on the survey. Similarly, we had participants complete the Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (Rosenberg, 1979) and the MacArthur Scale of Subjective Social Status (Adler et al., 2000). We hypothesized that there would be a positive correlation between participants' scores on these scales and their preferences for intrinsically rewarding options on the survey. In addition, we explored interaction effects between individuals' scores on the surveys and the prompts they were given: Perhaps, we imagined, genuinely lonely individuals would act differently than others exposed to one of the primes.

We also included the Centrality of Religiosity Scale (Huber & Huber, 2012). There is extensive evidence that religiosity leads to increased meaningfulness and well-being in individuals' lives (Yaden et al., 2022). Therefore, we hypothesized that there would be a positive correlation between participants' scores on these scales and their preferences for the intrinsically rewarding engagements on the survey. We, once again, felt this would be the case in all three of the conditions; we hypothesized that religiosity might function as an anchor of sorts—steering individuals away from tempting, though less fulfilling, status oriented options.

After this, we included the Social Media Use Scale (Tuck & Thompson, 2024) due to the increasing evidence that social media use has adverse mental health effects (Costello et al., 2023). A variety of studies show that excessive smartphone usage is associated with poor mental health outcomes, and substantial evidence suggests that these negative effects are driven by social media (Sohn et al., 2019). While this evidence is particularly striking in adolescents—and much media attention has focused on this body of work—these associations are by no means

confined to adolescents. Khan et al. (2023) demonstrated that excessive smartphone use in adults is linked with higher depression and stress scores, as well as more severe anxiety. Consequently, we hypothesized that there would be a negative correlation between individuals' scores on this scale and their preferences for intrinsically rewarding engagements on the survey; perhaps, we imagined, social media nudges individuals to prioritize self-presentation over intrinsic experience. A pattern of this sort could partially explain the negative mental health outcomes outlined above.

Finally, we included questions about gender, age, religious affiliation, and political affiliation to tease apart any differential effects in regard to these demographic variables.

All in all, Study 1 represents an initial attempt to explore how individuals weigh social relationships against status and related goods in decision-making scenarios. We hope, also, to illuminate the types of environmental influences and psychological traits that relate to individuals' preferences in these scenarios.

### **Study 1: Methods**

#### **Participants:**

The study included 160 participants,  $M(SD)$  age = 21.95 (5.17), 113 females, 41 males, 2 non-binary individuals, and 4 individuals who preferred not to list their genders. Participants were primarily recruited through Qualtrics from Brooklyn College Psychology 1000 classes. Brooklyn College students were given class credit for completing the survey but were not provided with any monetary compensation.

#### **Materials & Procedure:**



The study was administered on the website Qualtrics. It consisted of several survey instruments, each of which was scored as described below and converted into an overall proportion.

After consenting to participate in the survey, participants completed the 20-item Positive and Negative Affect Schedule (PANAS) (Watson et al., 1988). The instrument is composed of two mood scales, one measuring positive affect and the other measuring negative. Each item on the instrument is rated on a 5-point scale (ranging from 1 = very slightly or not at all, to 5 = extremely) to indicate the extent to which the respondent felt that way during the specified time frame. The PANAS was administered three times during the session. The first time the PANAS was administered, it was used to assess participants' baseline mood at the beginning of the experiment. Both positive and negative scores were summed and divided by 50 (the maximum possible score on each scale) to produce a final overall score.

After the first PANAS was administered, participants completed the UCLA Loneliness Scale (Russell, 1996). The UCLA Loneliness Scale consists of 20 Likert-scale items, ranging from one to four. On the scale, higher scores indicate greater loneliness and lower scores indicate less loneliness. (Note: Though the UCLA Loneliness Scale is a 20-item questionnaire, a mistake was made during the transcription of the scale into Qualtrics and the last two items were excluded. We felt that this would not have a substantial impact on the quality of the data, though, and opted to keep the 18-item questionnaire on Qualtrics to maintain consistency within the data. Proportions were calculated accordingly). Scores were summed and divided by seventy-two (the maximum possible score on the scale) to produce a final overall score.

After completing these two surveys, participants were randomly assigned to one of three conditions: Those in the first group were asked to reflect upon a scenario in which they were “socially connected,” those in the second group were asked to reflect upon a situation in which they were “socially isolated,” and those in the third group (the control group) were asked to reflect upon a “neutral situation” in which they were neither exceptionally well-connected nor exceptionally isolated, (see Appendix A for full text of the prompts). Each participant was asked to imagine that the situation they were assigned was real and spend five minutes writing a paragraph about what an average day in their life would be like in this situation. (Note: Participants were notified when five minutes had passed, yet were not explicitly restricted to five minutes nor required to write for a minimum of five minutes.) After completing this writing prompt, participants completed the PANAS once again. This second PANAS was used to assess the impact of the independent variable manipulation on participants’ moods.

Subsequently, all participants (regardless of which group they had been assigned) were given a newly devised survey instrument, the Relationship Orientation Scale. This scale consisted of twenty-two binary questions about hypothetical social scenarios; these questions involved explicit trade-offs between fostering and pursuing strong social relationships and attaining (or maintaining) social status. For instance, a prototypical question asked participants whether they would prefer to be admired or liked (see Appendix B for full question list). The response options were ordered so that the relationship option alternated between the first and second position across successive questions. Each question was scored as 0 or a 1 (0 corresponding to a status oriented option, and 1 to a relationship oriented option). Scores were then summed and divided by twenty-two (the maximum possible score on the scale) to produce a

final overall relationship orientation score. Consequently, higher scores on this survey indicated greater orientation towards social relationships, whereas lower scores indicated greater orientation toward social status.

After completing this survey, each participant was asked to rate the difficulty of answering these questions using a six-point Likert scale. Scores were divided by six (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score. Subsequently, participants were asked to spend three minutes writing a short paragraph about the “most important things” in their lives. (Note: As before, participants were notified when three minutes had passed but were not restricted to that time frame.)

After completing the survey and writing prompt, participants completed a battery of previously validated psychological instruments; we included these instruments to tease out correlations between individuals’ responses to the 22-question survey and participants’ behaviors, tendencies, and traits.

These included:

1. **Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale** (Rosenberg, 1979).

The Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale consists of ten Likert-scale items, ranging from one to four. High scores on this scale indicate high self-esteem, whereas low scores indicate low self-esteem. Scores were summed and divided by forty (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score.

2. **MacArthur Scale of Subjective Social Status** (Adler et al., 2000)

*Note: Due to Qualtrics limitations, this measure was adapted into a sliding scale rather than a visual ladder.*

The MacArthur Scale of Subjective Social Status consists of just one item: a sliding scale that functions as a visual representation of an individual's perceived social status. High scores on the scale indicate greater perceived social status, whereas low scores indicate lesser perceived social status. Though possible scores on the original ladder range from one to ten, the possible scores on our sliding scale ranged from one to nine due to graphical limitations of Qualtrics.

### 3. **Centrality of Religiosity Scale** (Huber & Huber, 2012)

The Centrality of Religiosity Scale consists of nineteen Likert-scale items, ranging from one to five. (Note: The scale contains fifteen main questions, four of which contain secondary sub-questions). High scores on the scale indicate greater religiosity, whereas low scores indicate lesser religiosity. Scores were summed and divided by ninety-five (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score.

### 4. **Social Media Use Scale** (Tuck & Thompson, 2024)

The Social Media Use Scale consists of seventeen Likert-scale items, ranging from one to nine. High scores on the scale indicate greater social media use, whereas low scores indicate lesser social media use. Scores were summed and divided by 153 (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score.

### 5. **15-item Big Five Personality Inventory** (Soto & John, 2017)

The 15-item Big Five Personality Inventory is subdivided into five sections (each of which represents a different personality dimension and consists of three questions). Each individual personality trait survey consists of three Likert-scale items, ranging from one

to five. A higher score on each trait indicates greater levels of the given trait, whereas a lesser score indicates lower levels of the given trait. For each respective trait, scores were summed and divided by 15 (the maximum possible score on each scale) to create a final overall score.

Finally, we had participants answer a number of questions about other traits (including age, gender, religious affiliation, and political affiliation). We then implemented the PANAS one final time, to determine how and if baseline mood had changed over the course of the survey.

Below are descriptive statistics for each of the measures. These descriptive statistics are derived from our own data.

**Table 1**

*Descriptive Statistics for Study 1*

| Measure                        | Mean | SD   | Range       | $\alpha$ |
|--------------------------------|------|------|-------------|----------|
| PANAS 1 +                      | .45  | .13  | .20 - .88   | .72      |
| PANAS 1 -                      | .49  | .15  | .20 - .84   | .76      |
| UCLA Loneliness Scale          | .62  | .14  | .28 - .97   | .92      |
| Relationship Orientation Scale | .71  | .14  | .36 - 1.00  | .67      |
| Question Difficulty            | 2.78 | 1.06 | 1.00 - 5.00 | NA       |
| PANAS 2 +                      | .42  | .13  | .20 - .84   | .77      |
| PANAS 2 -                      | .46  | .15  | .20 - .86   | .79      |
| Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale    | .70  | .17  | .28 - 1.00  | .89      |
| MacArthur Scale (SSS)          | 4.82 | 1.77 | 1.00 - 9.00 | NA       |

|                                 |       |      |            |     |
|---------------------------------|-------|------|------------|-----|
| Centrality of Religiosity Scale | .58   | .19  | .21 - .97  | .95 |
| Social Media Use Scale          | .38   | .17  | .11 - .90  | .91 |
| Openness (BFI-2)                | .70   | .17  | .33 - 1.00 | .49 |
| Conscientiousness (BFI-2)       | .64   | .17  | .27 - 1.00 | .35 |
| Extraversion (BFI-2)            | .56   | .17  | .20 - .93  | .52 |
| Agreeableness (BFI-2)           | .73   | .15  | .40 - 1.00 | .40 |
| Negative Emotionality (BFI-2)   | .64   | .19  | .20 - 1.00 | .54 |
| Age                             | 21.95 | 5.17 | 18 - 55    | NA  |
| PANAS 3 +                       | .42   | .14  | .20 - .80  | .81 |
| PANAS 3 -                       | .45   | .16  | .20 - .84  | .82 |

Note: We believe that the low Cronbach's alpha figures for the five personality traits reflect the low number of survey items for each personality trait.

### Study 1: Results

We first analyzed participants' scores on the 22-item Relationship Orientation Scale. As seen in Table 1, scores, when summed and converted to proportions, ranged from 0.36 to 1.00, with a mean of 0.71 ( $SD = 0.14$ ). The scale demonstrated moderate internal consistency (Cronbach's  $\alpha = .67$ ). A one-sample  $t$  test was conducted to determine whether participants' Relationship Orientation Scale scores differed from a mean of 0.50, the theoretical midpoint of the scale. The sample mean was higher than the theoretical mean,  $t(159) = 18.69, p < .001$ , Cohen's  $d = 1.48$ . This result indicates that participants, on average, displayed a strong

preference for relationship oriented outcomes compared to status oriented outcomes.

Nonetheless, a notable proportion of participants displayed a preference for status oriented outcomes.

Next, a one-way ANOVA was conducted to examine differences in Relationship Orientation Scale scores across the three prompt conditions (neutral, socially connected, and socially isolated). The analysis revealed no significant effect of prompt condition on relationship orientation scores,  $F(2, 157) = 0.77, p = .46, \eta^2 = .01$ . Due to the nonsignificant results and small effect size, the three groups were collapsed into one group for further analyses of the Relationship Orientation Scale.

We also analyzed the PANAS Positive scores in a repeated-measures ANOVA with the three PANAS administrations as the within-subjects variable and condition as the between-subjects variable. The within-subject effect was statistically reliable,  $F(2, 314) = 14.74, p < .001, \omega^2 = .01$ ; no effects were found for condition,  $F(2, 157) < 1$ , or the interaction,  $F(4, 314) < 1$ . The significant main effect is due to higher initial PANAS Positive scores,  $M(SD) = 0.45(0.13)$ , compared to the second and third administrations,  $M(SD) = 0.42(0.13)$  and  $0.42(0.14)$ , respectively. We also analyzed the PANAS Negative scores in a repeated-measures ANOVA with the three PANAS administrations as the within-subjects variable and condition as the between-subjects variable. The within-subject effect was statistically reliable,  $F(2, 314) = 18.28, p < .001, \omega^2 = .01$ ; no effects were found for condition,  $F(2, 157) < 1$ , or the interaction,  $F(4, 314) < 1$ . The significant main effect is due to higher initial PANAS Negative scores,  $M(SD) = 0.49(0.15)$ , compared to the second and third administrations,  $M(SD) = 0.46(0.15)$  and  $0.45(0.16)$ , respectively.

In addition to exploring participants' overall preferences on the Relationship Orientation Scale and the impact of prompt condition, we explored which individual characteristics predicted relationship orientation. Two regression analyses were conducted. The first was a full model regression with 18 variables: religiosity, question difficulty, PANAS 1 positive scores, PANAS 1 negative scores, PANAS 2 positive scores, PANAS 2 negative scores, PANAS 3 positive scores, PANAS 3 negative scores, subjective social status, social media use, loneliness, self-esteem, extraversion, agreeableness, conscientiousness, negative emotionality, openness, and age.

**Table 2**

*Full Regression Model for Study 1*

| Predictor                 | B     | SE   | $\beta$ | t     | p    |
|---------------------------|-------|------|---------|-------|------|
| Intercept                 | 0.50  | 0.17 | —       | 2.95  | .004 |
| Question Difficulty       | −0.02 | 0.01 | −0.13   | −1.42 | .157 |
| Centrality of Religiosity | 0.02  | 0.07 | 0.02    | 0.22  | .824 |
| PANAS 1 +                 | 0.06  | 0.24 | 0.06    | 0.26  | .795 |
| PANAS 1 -                 | −0.02 | 0.21 | −0.02   | −0.11 | .911 |
| PANAS 2 +                 | −0.26 | 0.25 | −0.23   | −1.05 | .298 |
| PANAS 2 -                 | 0.18  | 0.28 | 0.18    | 0.65  | .515 |
| PANAS 3 +                 | 0.28  | 0.25 | 0.26    | 1.13  | .262 |
| PANAS 3 -                 | −0.25 | 0.23 | −0.26   | −1.04 | .299 |



|                                             |       |      |       |       |      |
|---------------------------------------------|-------|------|-------|-------|------|
| MacArthur Scale of Subjective Social Status | 0.00  | 0.01 | 0.02  | 0.15  | .879 |
| Social Media Use                            | −0.20 | 0.08 | −0.24 | −2.39 | .019 |
| UCLA Loneliness                             | 0.01  | 0.13 | 0.01  | 0.09  | .925 |
| Rosenberg Self-Esteem                       | 0.01  | 0.13 | 0.01  | 0.09  | .925 |
| Extraversion (BFI-2)                        | −0.01 | 0.10 | −0.02 | −0.14 | .890 |
| Agreeableness (BFI-2)                       | −0.02 | 0.10 | −0.03 | −0.24 | .810 |
| Conscientiousness (BFI-2)                   | 0.06  | 0.09 | 0.06  | 0.67  | .505 |
| Negative Emotionality (BFI-2)               | 0.07  | 0.09 | 0.08  | 0.69  | .489 |
| Openness (BFI-2)                            | 0.21  | 0.08 | 0.25  | 2.61  | .010 |
| Age                                         | 0.01  | 0.00 | 0.19  | 2.07  | .041 |

The full model was only marginally predictive of Relationship Orientation Scale scores,  $F(18, 113) = 1.55, p = .087, R^2 = .20, Adjusted R^2 = .07$ . Nonetheless, three independent variables—social media use, openness, and age—were individually statistically significant. Openness and age were both positive predictors of relationship orientation, indicating that greater openness and higher age predicted higher relationship orientation. On the other hand, social media use showed a significant negative relationship, indicating that greater social media use predicted lower relationship orientation.

As a more parsimonious follow-up, a forward stepwise regression including these predictors was also conducted. This model was significant,  $F(3, 128) = 8.202$ ,  $p < .001$ ,  $R^2 = .167$ , *Adjusted  $R^2 = .142$* , and again identified the same three predictors as significant. The directionality and strength of these three predictors was comparable to that of the full regression.

**Table 3**

*Stepwise Regression Model for Study 1*

| Predictor        | B     | SE   | $\beta$ | t     | p      |
|------------------|-------|------|---------|-------|--------|
| Intercept        | 0.53  | 0.07 | —       | 7.25  | < .001 |
| Openness (BFI-2) | 0.20  | 0.07 | 0.24    | 2.91  | .004   |
| Social Media Use | −0.17 | 0.07 | −0.21   | −2.51 | .013   |
| Age              | 0.01  | 0.00 | 0.18    | 2.20  | .029   |

### Study 1: Discussion

Study 1 explored how individuals weigh the value of social connection against the value of social status in a range of different scenarios. Several general results stand out. First, participants displayed a strong tendency to choose relationship oriented options compared to status oriented options. The average score on the Relationship Orientation Scale was 71%, which was significantly above the 50% midpoint of the scale. Second, social media use negatively predicted relationship orientation. (Openness and age also emerged as positive predictors of relationship orientation; yet, we believe that the explanatory power of these two variables should

be treated with caution, due to the low internal reliability of the openness scale in our survey and the limited age range of the sample). Finally, participants' preferences on the Relationship Orientation Scale were stable. Primes pertaining to loneliness and social connection did not alter participants' preferences.

Despite participants' general preference for relationship oriented options, a small but meaningful minority of participants (around 8%) displayed a general preference for the status oriented options. There are a number of possible explanations for this variability. One possibility is that status orientation is related not to loneliness or low self-esteem or even self-perception of low social status (as we initially theorized), but a tendency towards comparison. Perhaps these individuals' preoccupation with status reflects a pronounced concern about their position within the social hierarchy, regardless of what that perceived position might be. In Study 2, we incorporated the Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale to address this question. We also asked participants to estimate their own Relationship Orientation Scale scores and the Relationship Orientation Scale scores of others in order to understand how participants contextualized their estimates.

Another potential explanation for high status orientation is that it reflects a failure of affective forecasting. It is possible that status oriented individuals do not understand what types of decisions or outcomes ultimately enhance their well-being. Alternatively, it is possible that status oriented individuals are unusually good affective forecasters (or, at the very least, no worse at forecasting than relationship oriented individuals). Although our study utilized a variety of different psychometric tests, it did not directly compare overall well-being to relationship orientation. As a result, we cannot rule out the possibility that there is no clear association

between overall well-being and relationship orientation, or a negative correlation between these two variables. To examine this question, we included a previously validated flourishing scale in the second study.

The emergence of social media use as a significant predictor also warrants discussion. Despite a host of different functions, social media is often conceptualized as a mechanism which increases rates of social comparison. Social media users frequently spend time comparing their appearances, personal lives, and professional accomplishments to those of others. Therefore, the finding that social media negatively predicts relationship orientation suggests that comparative behavior is associated with relationship orientation and the directionality of this association is negative. While, due to the correlational nature of this study, we cannot establish whether this association is causal, we can explore its implications in finer detail. In the second study, we implemented the Social Media Use Scale once again, and we explored its association with general comparative tendencies.

Finally, the fact that our written prompt manipulation had no significant effect is notable. A potential explanation for this lack of effect is the possibility that relationship orientation, unlike mood, is a relatively stable trait and cannot be easily altered. However, a number of factors from our study complicate this picture. There appears to have been a significant mood change from before and after the prompts, with the PANAS positive scores being significantly reduced. This effect held stable for the three conditions. The one commonality between these three conditions was the administration of the UCLA Loneliness Scale. It is possible, therefore, that prompting individuals to reflect on their loneliness reduced their mood and therefore “flattened” any effects of the independent variable manipulation on the Relationship Orientation

Scale. We opted to include this scale at the beginning of the survey to ensure that individuals' scores on this scale were not impacted by the independent variable manipulation. However, it is possible that a replication of this study that excluded this scale might demonstrate a different effect.

## **Study 2**

In our second study, we aimed to replicate our general findings about the Relationship Orientation Scale. We hypothesized that participants would, once again, display a significant preference for the relationship oriented options over status oriented options. We also implemented a more comprehensive survey of personality traits, a flourishing scale, a scale assessing comparative tendencies, and the Social Media Use Scale. Specifically, we hypothesized that comparative tendency and social media use would emerge as negative predictors of relationship orientation. In addition, we included a number of questions surrounding social metacognition by asking participants to estimate both their own Relationship Orientation Scale scores and the Relationship Orientation Scale scores of others. Overall, we hoped that this combination of instruments and questions would allow us to expand upon and begin to answer the questions posed by Study 1.

### **Study 2: Methods**

#### **Participants:**

The study included 139 participants,  $M(SD)$  age = 20.2 (3.22), 93 females, 41 males, 3 non-binary individuals, and 2 individuals who preferred not to list their genders. Participants were primarily recruited through Qualtrics from Brooklyn College Psychology 1000 classes.

Brooklyn College students were given class credit for completing the survey but were not provided with any monetary compensation.

### **Materials & Procedure:**

The study was administered on the website Qualtrics. It consisted of several survey instruments, each of which was scored as described below and converted into an overall proportion. After consenting to participate in the survey, participants completed a battery of previously validated psychological instruments, as well as the novel Relationship Orientation Scale. In sequential order, these included:

#### **1. Flourishing Scale (Diener et al., 2009)**

The Flourishing Scale consists of eight Likert-scale items, ranging from one to seven. On the scale, higher scores indicate greater psychological well-being and lower scores indicate lesser psychological well-being. Scores were summed and divided by fifty-six (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score.

#### **2. Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale (Gibbons & Buunk, 1999)**

The Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale consists of eleven Likert-scale items, ranging from one to five. Higher scores indicate a stronger tendency towards comparing oneself with others, whereas lower scores indicate a weaker tendency towards comparing oneself with others. Scores were summed and divided by fifty-five (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score. (Note: The original scale was written in German and translated into English; minor changes were made to the translated language in order to ensure clarity and comprehensibility for participants).

#### **3. International Personality Item Pool (Johnson, 2014)**

This instrument consists of 120 questions pertaining to individuals' psychometric personality traits (openness, negative emotionality, extraversion, agreeableness, and conscientiousness). Each trait is measured on a scale ranging from one to five, with higher scores indicating greater levels of said trait and lower scores indicating lower levels of said trait. For each respective trait, scores were summed and divided by 120 (the maximum possible score on each scale) to create a final overall score.

#### **4. Social Media Use Scale (Tuck & Thompson, 2024)**

The Social Media Use Scale consists of seventeen Likert-scale items, ranging from one to nine. It is identical to the scale that was presented in the first study. Higher scores on the scale indicate greater social media use, whereas lower scores indicate lesser social media use. Scores were summed and divided by 153 (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score. Participants were also asked to indicate which social media sites they used (see Appendix C for statistics).

#### **5. Relationship Orientation Scale**

This scale consists of twenty-two binary questions, with higher scores indicating greater relationship orientation and lower scores indicating lower relationship orientation. It is identical to the scale which was presented in the initial survey, barring a few questions with slightly altered language. These alterations were implemented to ensure clarity. Scores were summed and divided by twenty-two (the maximum possible score on the scale) to create a final overall score. Participants also completed a brief survey regarding which specific social media sites they used.

Finally, participants received a brief explanation of the study and a number of questions about their perceptions or how they had scored on the survey. They were asked to estimate what they believed they had scored on the survey, what they believed the average score of others on the survey was, whether their past actions reflected their indicated survey preferences (see Appendix D), and what factors may have influenced any discrepancies between their past actions and their indicated survey preferences (see Appendix E). Individuals' estimations of their own relationship orientation scores were subtracted from their actual relationship orientation scores to calculate "self estimation accuracy"; and individuals' estimations of others' relationship orientation scores were subtracted from others' actual relationship orientation scores to calculate "other estimation accuracy." The study concluded with standard demographic questions about age, gender, religion, and political affiliation.

Below are descriptive statistics for each of these measures. These descriptive statistics are derived from our own data.

**Table 4**

*Descriptive Statistics for Study 2*

| Measure                                          | Mean | SD  | Range      | $\alpha$ |
|--------------------------------------------------|------|-----|------------|----------|
| Flourishing Scale                                | .77  | .13 | .21 - 1.00 | .85      |
| Iowa-Netherlands Comparison<br>Orientation Scale | .67  | .17 | .20 - 1.00 | .87      |
| Openness (IPIP-NEO)                              | .68  | .09 | .48 - .89  | .77      |
| Conscientiousness (IPIP-NEO)                     | .65  | .10 | .34 - .92  | .85      |



|                                  |       |       |                 |     |
|----------------------------------|-------|-------|-----------------|-----|
| Extraversion (IPIP-NEO)          | .60   | .09   | .36 - .82       | .81 |
| Agreeableness (IPIP-NEO)         | .71   | .09   | .46 - .95       | .80 |
| Negative Emotionality (IPIP-NEO) | .65   | .11   | .33 - .90       | .87 |
| Social Media Use Scale           | .38   | .18   | .11 - .90       | .93 |
| Relationship Orientation Scale   | .71   | .15   | .32 - 1.00      | .65 |
| Age                              | 20.17 | 3.22  | 17 - 39         | NA  |
| Personal ROS Score Estimation    | .69   | .24   | 0.00 - 1.00     | NA  |
| Estimation of Others' ROS Scores | .67   | .19   | 0.00 - 1.00     | NA  |
| Self Estimation Accuracy         | -2.40 | 24.68 | -80.95 - +50.00 | NA  |
| Other Estimation Accuracy        | -3.89 | 22.71 | -60.91 - +68.18 | NA  |

## Study 2: Results

We first analyzed participants' scores on the 22-item Relationship Orientation Scale. As seen in Table 4, scores, when summed and converted to proportions, ranged from 0.32 to 1.00, with a mean of 0.71 ( $SD = 0.15$ ). The scale demonstrated moderate internal consistency (Cronbach's  $\alpha = .65$ ). A one-sample  $t$  test was conducted to determine whether participants' Relationship Orientation Scale scores differed from a mean of 0.50, the theoretical midpoint of the scale. The sample mean was higher than the theoretical mean,  $t(138) = 17.05, p < .001$ , Cohen's  $d = 1.45$ . This result indicates that participants, on average, displayed a strong preference for relationship oriented outcomes compared to status oriented outcomes.

Nonetheless, a notable proportion of participants displayed a preference for status oriented outcomes.

In addition to exploring participants' overall preferences on the Relationship Orientation Scale, we explored which individual characteristics predicted relationship orientation. We conducted a full model regression with nine variables: flourishing, comparison orientation, social media use, extraversion, agreeableness, conscientiousness, negative emotionality, openness, and age.

**Table 5**

*Full Regression Model for Study 2 (Predicting ROS)*

| Predictor                                     | B     | SE   | $\beta$ | t     | p    |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------|------|---------|-------|------|
| Intercept                                     | 0.62  | 0.20 | NA      | 3.11  | .002 |
| Flourishing Scale                             | −0.01 | 0.01 | −0.05   | −0.62 | .536 |
| Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale | −0.03 | 0.02 | −0.18   | −2.02 | .045 |
| Social Media Use                              | −0.02 | 0.01 | −0.24   | −2.69 | .008 |
| Negative Emotionality                         | 0.00  | 0.03 | 0.02    | 0.17  | .868 |
| Extraversion (IPIP-NEO)                       | −0.02 | 0.03 | −0.05   | −0.59 | .559 |
| Openness (IPIP-NEO)                           | 0.05  | 0.03 | 0.15    | 1.66  | .100 |
| Agreeableness (IPIP-NEO)                      | 0.10  | 0.03 | 0.29    | 3.02  | .003 |
| Conscientiousness (IPIP-NEO)                  | −0.02 | 0.03 | −0.08   | −0.81 | .422 |
| Age                                           | 0.00  | 0.00 | −0.09   | −1.16 | .246 |

The full model was statistically significant and predictive of relationship orientation,  $F(9, 129) = 5.34$ ,  $p < .01$ ,  $R^2 = .27$ , Adjusted  $R^2 = .22$ . Three independent variables—comparison orientation, social media use, and agreeableness—were individually statistically significant. Agreeableness was a positive predictor of relationship orientation, indicating that greater agreeableness predicted higher relationship orientation. On the other hand, both Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale and Social Media Use scores showed significant negative relationships, indicating that greater social comparison orientation and greater social media use predicted lower relationship orientation.

As an exploratory analysis, we explored which individual characteristics predicted flourishing. We conducted a full model regression with nine variables: relationship orientation, comparison orientation, social media use, extraversion, agreeableness, conscientiousness, negative emotionality, openness, and age.

**Table 6**

*Exploratory Full Regression Model for Study 2 (Predicting Flourishing)*

| Predictor                                     | B     | SE   | $\beta$ | t     | p    |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------|------|---------|-------|------|
| Intercept                                     | 3.46  | 1.29 | NA      | 2.69  | .008 |
| Relationship Orientation Scale                | −0.35 | 0.56 | −0.06   | −0.62 | .536 |
| Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale | 0.07  | 0.11 | 0.07    | 0.70  | .486 |

|                                     |       |      |       |       |       |
|-------------------------------------|-------|------|-------|-------|-------|
| Social Media Use                    | −0.05 | 0.05 | −0.08 | −0.88 | .380  |
| Negative Emotionality<br>(IPIP-NEO) | −0.07 | 0.17 | −0.04 | −0.42 | .675  |
| Extraversion (IPIP-NEO)             | 0.47  | 0.18 | 0.23  | 2.61  | .010  |
| Openness (IPIP-NEO)                 | 0.13  | 0.20 | 0.06  | 0.64  | .521  |
| Agreeableness (IPIP-NEO)            | −0.25 | 0.22 | −0.12 | −1.14 | .258  |
| Conscientiousness (IPIP-NEO)        | 0.67  | 0.18 | 0.36  | 3.79  | <.001 |
| Age                                 | −0.04 | 0.02 | −0.15 | −1.91 | .058  |

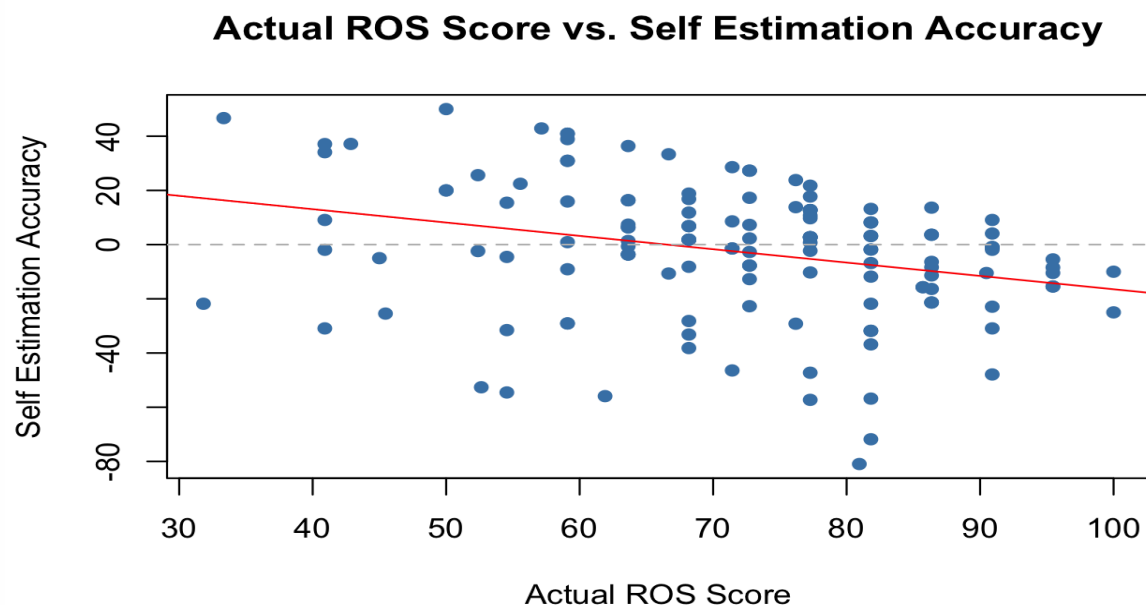
The full model was statistically significant and predictive of flourishing,  $F(9, 129) = 4.70$ ,  $p < .01$ ,  $R^2 = .25$ , Adjusted  $R^2 = .19$ . Two independent variables — extraversion and conscientiousness — were individually statistically significant. Both were positive predictors of flourishing scores, indicating that greater extraversion and greater conscientiousness predicted higher Flourishing Scale scores.

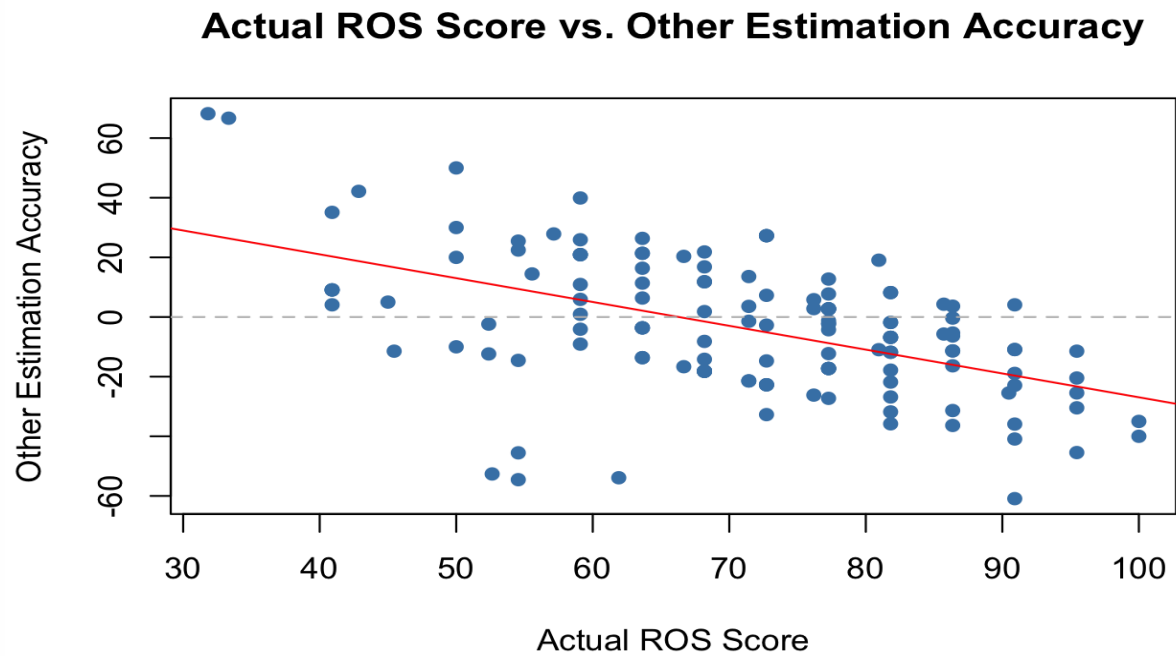
We also explored the manner in which participants' various score estimations were associated with one another. Three Pearson correlations were conducted. Participants' estimates of their own scores were significantly and positively correlated with their actual Relationship Orientation Scale scores,  $r(133) = .30$ ,  $p < .001$ . Participants' estimates of their own scores were also significantly positively correlated with their estimates of others' scores,  $r(132) = .30$ ,  $p < .001$ . However, participants' estimates of others' scores were not significantly correlated with actual Relationship Orientation Scale scores,  $r(135) = .15$ ,  $p = .077$ .

Finally, we explored the accuracy of participants' estimations and how these related to actual relationship orientation. Shapiro-Wilk tests indicated that self estimation accuracy scores were non-normally distributed ( $W = .976, p = .019$ ). Self estimation accuracy scores were significantly and negatively correlated with actual relationship orientation,  $r(133) = -.29, p < .001$  (see Figure 1). A one-sample t-test revealed that self estimation accuracy did not differ significantly from zero ( $t(134) = -1.13, p = .261$ ), suggesting no systematic overestimation or underestimation of one's own relationship orientation.

Other estimation accuracy scores were approximately normally distributed ( $W = .988, p = .258$ ). Other estimation accuracy scores were significantly and negatively correlated with actual relationship orientation,  $r(135) = -.52, p < .001$  (see Figure 2). Other estimation accuracy differed significantly from zero ( $t(136) = -2.00, p = .047$ ), indicating a small but significant tendency to underestimate others' scores ( $M = -3.89, SD = 22.71$ ).

**Figure 1**



**Figure 2**

### Study 2: Discussion

Study 2 replicated and built upon the findings of Study 1. Participants, once again, displayed a strong preference for the relationship oriented options, with the mean score being 71%—significantly above the 50% midpoint on the scale. Social media use and comparison orientation (as measured by the Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale) emerged as significant negative predictors of relationship orientation. These predictors, along with agreeableness (a significant positive predictor of relationship orientation) contributed to a statistically significant full model which accounted for approximately 27% of the variance in relationship orientation.

## General Discussion

Psychological research on well-being has traditionally centered around the strength and extent of individuals' social relationships. However, little research has focused on how individuals conceptualize social relationships and weigh different social goods against one another. Here, in two studies, we explored how individuals weigh social status against intrinsic social connection in a range of decision-making scenarios. In Study 1, we primarily examined the role of social belonging and self-esteem in determining individuals' preferences. In Study 2, we focused on the role of personality traits, dispositional tendencies, and social metacognition.

Several general results stand out. The first is the association between comparative behavior and low relationship orientation. This association is demonstrated by the emergence of both comparison orientation and social media use as negative predictors of relationship orientation. While not surprising per se, this association is notable because it suggests that we tend to compare our levels of social status, not our levels of social connection, with those of others. There is no a priori reason why this must be the case. Social media is saturated with images communicating status—yet it is also saturated with images communicating the strength of different social relationships. The Iowa-Netherlands Comparison Orientation Scale, likewise, does not neatly distinguish comparisons of social status from comparisons of social connection. One could easily imagine the intrinsic qualities of social connection driving the majority of comparative behavior. The fact that social media use and comparison orientation negatively predict relationship orientation, however, suggests that this is not the case.

Interestingly, the relationship between comparison orientation and social media use was not as strong as one might expect, despite being among the highest correlations in both studies (see Appendices F and G). This suggests that social media use may be impacting individuals' relationship orientation through mechanisms other than the augmentation of comparative behavior. One possibility is that the images and ideas commonly circulated on social media are genuinely altering the self-perceived values of users. Further research is needed to determine what other factors might be underlying these various associations. Further research is also needed to determine whether the impact of social media use on comparison orientation and relationship orientation is causal.

The second noteworthy result is the lack of a meaningful association between relationship orientation and flourishing—a finding which suggests that relationship orientation and flourishing should be treated as distinct constructs. Though our overall regression model predicting relationship orientation was significant, as was our exploratory regression model predicting flourishing, neither relationship orientation nor flourishing were significant individual predictors in either model. In fact, the respective models shared none of the same significant individual predictors. The role of personality traits in both models sheds light on this contrast. In our model predicting flourishing, conscientiousness and extraversion were the only two significant predictors (though age was marginally significant). This is consistent with past literature which has frequently demonstrated that these two traits are positive predictors of flourishing (Soto, 2015). However, in our model predicting relationship orientation, agreeableness was the only personality trait that emerged as significant.



The emergence of agreeableness as a significant predictor warrants further comment.

Two traits captured by the construct of agreeableness, the drive to maintain social harmony and the propensity to emphasize the needs of others, function as logical explanations for low status orientation. This implicit connection, though perhaps intuitive, deserves careful analysis. There is no inherent reason why the prioritization of social connection over status would necessarily be a proxy for agreeableness. After all, there are countless situations in which one might maintain social harmony by pursuing certain types of professional or financial success over social connection. The fact that agreeable individuals tend to prefer the relationship oriented options in our survey tells us something about the personality trait itself—it may be driven by a genuine preference for social connection as much as a behavioral disposition towards social harmony. A worthwhile follow-up study might explore how agreeable individuals approach situations in which they must explicitly make trade-offs between maintaining social harmony and pursuing or strengthening social connections.

Overall, the tension between indicated preference and actual behavior is one that informed much of this study. In addition to our primary analyses, we asked participants a number of questions pertaining to social metacognition to begin to explore this relationship. In particular, we looked at how accurate individuals were at estimating their own Relationship Orientation Scale scores, as well as how accurate they were at estimating the Relationship Orientation Scale scores of others. The correlation between self estimation accuracy and actual relationship orientation was significant and negative, suggesting that the capacity to accurately assess one's relationship orientation is inversely related with one's true relationship orientation. It may be the case that accurate self-knowledge gives individuals the bandwidth to be more status oriented and,

simultaneously, maintain relationships devoid of conflict. However, the correlation was weak and non-normally distributed. Additionally, neither a systematic overestimation or underestimation was observed. As such, we hesitate to draw strong conclusions from this particular association.

Other estimation accuracy proved a more illuminating metric. Notably, we found that there was a moderate negative correlation between individuals' actual Relationship Orientation Scale scores and their accuracy in predicting the scores of others. Individuals with high actual Relationship Orientation Scale scores appear to slightly underestimate the Relationship Orientation Scale scores of others. Though, at first glance, this finding seems counterintuitive, we believe that it contributes to a coherent picture of relationship orientation. Initially, we theorized that individuals might pursue status as “insurance” against loneliness and general insecurity. However, our first study demonstrated no meaningful associations between relationship orientation and these variables. The results of our second study, though, compelled us to retain and reconceptualize this “insurance framework.” We now believe that relationship orientation is related not to general social well-being, but to certain types of emotional intelligence and dispositional tendency. In particular, we believe that individuals with trouble calibrating the preferences of others may prioritize social connection to “protect against” the issues these miscalibrations can cause. In our view, this prioritization is neither good nor bad—merely one snapshot of how individuals address this particular perspective-taking limitation. Further research should examine whether the aforementioned miscalibration is, in fact, related to social well-being, and whether high relationship orientation functions as a meaningful remedy for the issues this discrepancy tends to cause.

There are several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings of these studies. First, the samples of both studies were drawn primarily from introductory psychology courses at Brooklyn College. Moreover, participants in both studies were predominantly young and female. The limited age range, in particular, should be treated with caution. Age emerged as a significant predictor of relationship orientation in our first study and a significant predictor of flourishing in our exploratory model from the second study. Consequently, there is reason to believe that a similar study sampling from a broader age range might display different results.

The fact that Cronbach's alpha was .67 in the first study and .65 in the second also warrants specific comment. Both statistics, of course, fall below the .70 that is generally considered the threshold for adequate internal consistency. That said, we do not necessarily feel that the gap between these numbers and .70 is particularly meaningful given the nature of the scale. The Relationship Orientation Scale, unlike many other surveys, was designed to present participants with a range of different decision-making scenarios; these scenarios addressed aspects of life as diverse as professional success, friendship, and romance. They also involved both specific scenarios and general preferences. As a result, we feel that the survey's relatively low alpha reflects the variability of the construct, not issues with the specific survey design. Perhaps most importantly, we believe that our ability to consistently identify variables that predicted participants' scores would have been impossible if the survey did not measure a reliable underlying construct.

These limitations aside, we believe that our studies provide strong preliminary evidence that relationship orientation is a meaningful construct, relationship orientation is associated with

both indicated behaviors and dispositional tendencies, and relationship orientation has no clear association with flourishing. The last of these findings, though, merits considerable reflection. One superficial reading of this finding is as follows: Walinger confirmed the intuitions of Aristotle and Epicurus by demonstrating that strong social relationships lead to flourishing; we, however, demonstrated that the actual characteristics of these relationships and the actual motivations underlying these relationships may be largely irrelevant. We would strongly dissuade readers from this particular interpretation.

First, we were not able to measure real-world behavior in any meaningful sense. Therefore, we have no strong evidence that individuals' preferences on the Relationship Orientations Scale (or any of the other surveys, for that matter) necessarily correspond to their actions. Second (and perhaps more importantly) we believe that this interpretation reflects a general misunderstanding of the goals of positive psychology and psychometrics. The scales that psychologists in these domains use are descriptive instruments, not definitive answers to philosophical questions. The nature of the Flourishing Scale itself is an apt demonstration of this misunderstanding. Though the Flourishing Scale is an excellent psychometric scale with high internal consistency and replicability, it reflects a very particular understanding of human flourishing. Specifically, it reflects the notion that flourishing is a result of how individuals feel about themselves and their lives. We began this paper by noting that the Greek term *eudaimonia* is *loosely* translatable as well-being, and we believe this caveat is worth bearing in mind. There may be moral goods that contribute to *eudaimonia* that are not adequately captured by scales such as the Flourishing Scale. For instance, one may dedicate themselves to improving the lives of

those around them, yet not perceive themselves to be “flourishing” due to the myriad challenges that arise from this goal.

In contrast, we would urge our readers to view our findings as provocations—provocations to think deeply about the types of lives they wish to lead and whether or not they live in a society which allows them to lead these lives. Though science often has the valence of moral neutrality, it is impossible to ignore the moral nature of the questions posed by this work. The salient question is not whether there is a direct association between relationship orientation and flourishing. The salient question is whether we wish to lead lives in which there is such an association. The answer may be that we wish to, yet doing so involves an intense reexamination of both our personal lives and society at large; conversely, the answer may be that human psychology itself prevents such “re-engineering projects” and such pursuits create more harm than good. Regardless, engagement with these questions is vital. The philosopher Susan Neiman aptly summarizes this general project in her book *Why Grow Up? Subversive Thoughts for an Infantile Age*:

The same drive that allows us to imagine that things could be different than they are given to us functions in science and social justice alike. Refusal to accept what is, as a necessary condition, is the source of human strength... It demands that we learn the difference between is and ought without ever giving up on either one. (Neiman, 2014, p. 127)

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## Appendix A: Open-Response Prompts

### **Neutral Prompt:**

Imagine you are neither exceptionally lonely nor surrounded by people you love. You have a number of friends, some of whom you see on a regular basis; likewise, you have a number of family members you are in regular contact with. There are a fair number of people you feel comfortable reaching out to—some of whom would readily answer a message or call from you, some of whom would not. You believe that you make some difference to the people around you.

At times, you are able to initiate new relationships. At other times, you are not. Expanding your social circle is neither particularly easy nor particularly difficult for you.

Imagine you are a person in this scenario. Spend five minutes writing about what a typical day in your life is like.

### **Negative Independent Variable:**

Imagine you are completely alone. You have lost touch with or severed ties with all friends; you have lost touch with or severed ties with all family members. There is nobody you feel comfortable reaching out to; in fact, there is not a single person who would answer your messages or calls. As far as you can tell, you make no difference to anyone at all.

You have tried, but you have been unable to initiate new relationships of any sort. Each time you reach out to someone new, you are ignored, rejected, or dogged by the intense feeling that you are not valued. Your efforts are, as far as you can tell, completely hopeless.

Imagine you are a person in this scenario. Spend five minutes writing about what a typical day in your life is like.

**Positive Independent Variable:**

Imagine you are surrounded by people you love. You have countless fulfilling friendships; you have exceptionally strong ties with family members. There are innumerable people you feel comfortable reaching out to on a moment's notice. It is abundantly clear to you that you have made a positive impact on many lives.

When you wish, it is remarkably easy for you to initiate new relationships of any sort. Each time you reach out to someone new, you are listened to, accepted, and filled with the overwhelming feeling that you are valued. Your efforts to form new relationships are virtually always fruitful.

Imagine you are a person in this scenario. Spend five minutes writing about what a typical day in your life is like.

## Appendix B: Relationship Orientation Scale

*Note: Items with asterices indicate the “relationship oriented” option.*

You are single and your friend offers to set you up on a date. He/she says there are two options available. Which individual would you prefer to go on a date with, if forced to choose:

- A. An individual your friend describes as “remarkably attractive” and whom your friend says you’ll “get along with fine.”
- B. An individual your friend describes as having “average looks” and whom your friend says you’ll “get along with great.”\*

You are single and your friend offers to set you up on a date. He/she says there are two options available. Which individual would you prefer to go on a date with, if forced to choose:

- A. An individual your friend describes as “remarkably successful” and whom your friend says “you’ll get along with fine.”
- B. An individual your friend describes as having “an average job” and whom your friend says “you’ll get along with great.”\*

If forced to choose, would you prefer to be friends with:

- A. An individual with a tremendous amount of wealth and influence, whom you get along with fine.
- B. An individual with wealth and influence comparable to your own, whom you get along with great.\*

If forced to choose, would you prefer to be professionally acquainted with:

- A. An individual with a tremendous amount of wealth and influence, whom you get along with fine.
- B. An individual with wealth and influence comparable to your own, whom you get along with great.\*

Would you prefer to:

- A. Have a large number of casual friends you are content with.
- B. Have a small number of close friends you are content with.\*

Would you prefer to:

- A. Have a large number of casual friends, the majority of whom you do not particularly like.
- B. Have a small number of close friends, all of whom you like.\*

It is more important to me that I:

- A. Have a professional career that I am proud of and that garners me recognition.
- B. Have fulfilling personal relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.).\*

I am more concerned with my social acquaintances:

- A. Admiring me.
- B. Liking me.\*

Would you prefer to be:

- A. A physically attractive person with trouble maintaining fulfilling relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.)
- B. A physically unattractive person with fulfilling personal relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.).\*

Would you prefer to be:

- A. An influential person with trouble maintaining fulfilling relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.)
- B. An uninfluential person with fulfilling personal relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.).\*

Would you prefer to be:

- A. A rich person with trouble maintaining fulfilling relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.)
- B. A poor person with fulfilling personal relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.).\*

Would you prefer to:

- A. Have a career that garners you considerable wealth, but that you are not passionate about.
- B. Have a career that does not garner you considerable wealth, but that you are passionate about.\*

Would you prefer to:

- A. Have a career that is considerably influential, but that you are not passionate about.
- B. Have a career that is not considerably influential, but that you are passionate about.\*

I am more inclined to envy:

- A. People who are more impressive than me.
- B. People who are more content than me.\*

I am more inclined to admire:

- A. People who are more impressive than me.
- B. People who are more content than me.\*

It is more important to me that:

- A. Have a career that impresses others.
- B. Have a career that interests me.\*

It is more important to me that I:

- A. Have a career that others admire.
- B. Have a career that interests me.\*

I would rather:

- A. Do something I believe to be morally wrong that improves my social reputation.
- B. Do something I believe to be morally right that harms my social reputation.\*

I would rather:

- A. Do something I believe to be morally wrong that improves my status.
- B. Do something I believe to be morally right that harms my status. \*

I would rather:

- A. Be disliked, yet widely admired.
- B. Be well-liked, yet not widely admired.\*

I am more concerned with:

- A. Pursuing my individual goals.
- B. Maintaining my social relationships (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.)\*

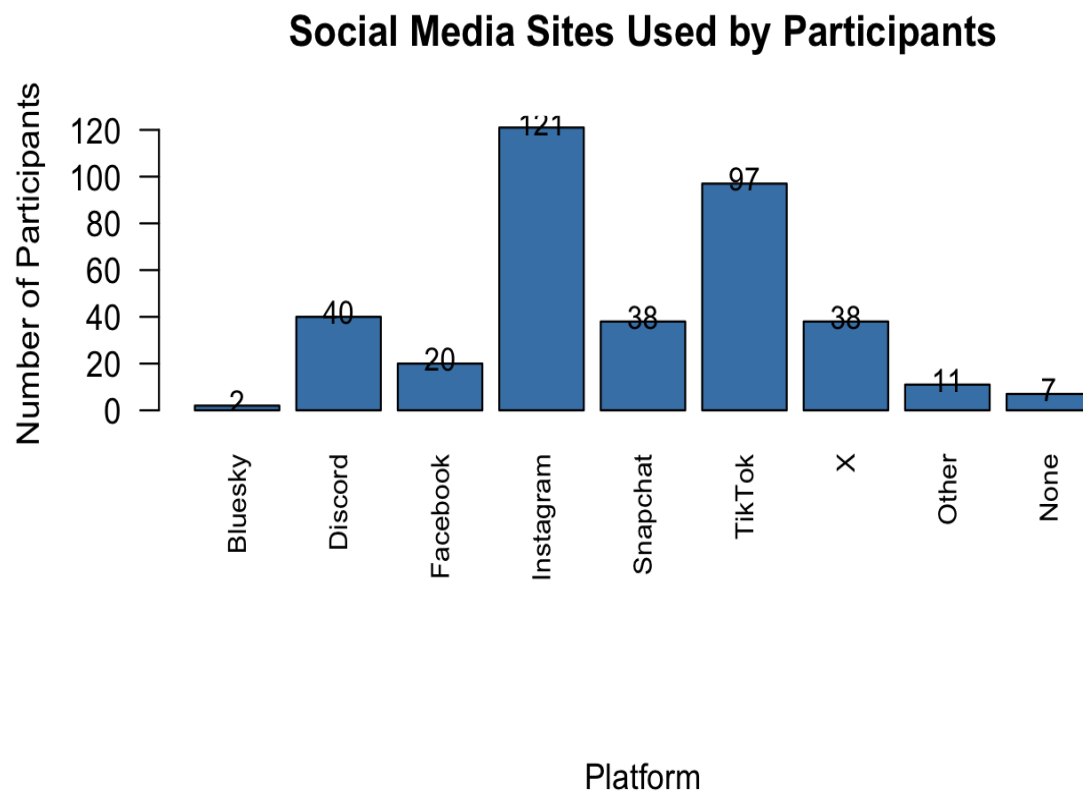
I am more concerned with:

- A. Not living up to my professional potential.
- B. Letting down people I know (family, friends, romantic relationships, etc.)\*

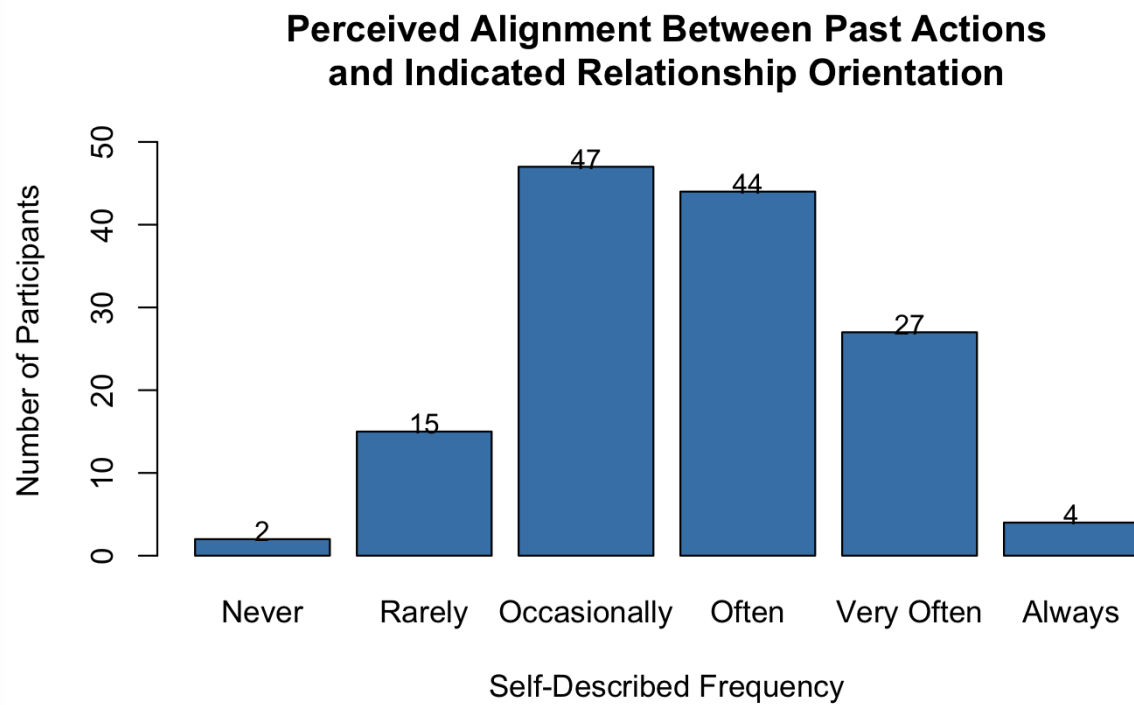


## Appendix C: Social Media Sites Used

Figure 3



## Appendix D: Perceived Alignment Between Past Actions and Indicated Relationship Orientation

**Figure 4**

Appendix E: Perceived Reasons for Disparities Between Past Actions and Indicated Relationship Orientation

Figure 5

